Questions to Ask Mom, the People Who Help Her, and the People the Family Is Counting On

Fifteen questions, sorted by who can answer them, with room to write what they say.

The neighbor knows how the driving works. Your brother knows the bills. Mom knows what her days are like. Each question below sits under the person who can answer it firsthand.

Ask them as they are, in whatever order the visits and phone calls happen, and write the answer under each one. This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. Nobody has to be doing anything wrong for you to ask them.

Mom

Start here. It's her week, and her account of it goes on the page in her own words.

1. In an ordinary week, who do you count on, and for what?

2. Is there anything you'd like in your week that isn't happening now?

3. If one of us were away for a week or two, who would you want us to ask to fill in?

The people who help her now

The neighbor who drives, your brother with the bills, and anyone else on the list. Ask because each of them knows their part best.

1. What do you do for Mom in an ordinary week, and how often? Have we left anything off the list?

2. Is there anything about how you do it that someone filling in would need to know?

3. How does your part fit with the rest of your week, and is there any piece of it you'd like to share?

4. When you're away, what happens to your part now?

The people the family thinks of as backup

The relative or friend whose name comes up when someone says “if it came to that.” They may not know they've been mentioned.

1. Your name comes up when we talk about who could fill in for Mom. Had anyone asked you?
2. Which parts could you really do, and which couldn't you?
3. What would you need to know, or have, before you could?

Each other

1. Which jobs does only one of us do today?
2. Where do two of us remember an arrangement differently?
3. What kind of change would make us look at this list again?

Mom's doctor or pharmacist

Only for questions about her health or her medications, and with Mom's say-so.

1. A few questions about Mom's health came up while we were making our list. Here they are in writing. Who should each one go to?

Your care consultant

Someone who meets Mom as well as talking with the family, and looks at the whole picture.

1. Given our list of who does what, which backups have been agreed and what's still open, what else would you want to know?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, tell you which comes first, or say what an answer means for Mom's support. Write each answer the way it was given, including “no” and “I'd have to think about it.”

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions sorted by who can answer them, and soon some answers. The care interview walks through Mom's daily life area by area, so each answer has a place to go, and turns them into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

A few of these questions follow the National Institute on Aging's page on sharing caregiving, which suggests asking who can step in to help, and the Family Caregiver Alliance's page on backup planning, which says to ask a likely helper about their willingness. The grouping by person is ours.

1. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Smart Caregiving by FCA: Backup Planning